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What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Paramount reached** a settlement with state attorneys general that clears the way for its \$81 billion merger with Warner Bros. Discovery that is poised to reshape Hollywood. **A1**
- ◆ **Investors bid up** the price of Meta Platform's shares, setting the tone for Monday's session, which saw the S&P 500, Nasdaq and Dow rise 1.5%, 2.3% and 0.7%, respectively. **B1**
- ◆ **Silver Lake asked** a judge to declare that Carl Icahn and a group of hedge funds illegally colluded to try to quash the private-equity firm's \$13 billion acquisition of Endeavor. **B1**
- ◆ **CarMax slashed** 145 white-collar jobs, or about 4% of its corporate staff, as it sought to boost its competitiveness in a climate of higher vehicle prices and rising interest rates. **B1**
- ◆ **Ethan Allen engaged** an executive search firm to evaluate potential candidates to become the furniture maker's next chief executive. **B2**
- ◆ **Swedish autonomous-truck** maker Einride looked to Nvidia for computing power and the artificial-intelligence tools needed to develop its self-driving systems. **B3**
- ◆ **The Qatar Investment Authority** and JPMorgan Chase went into partnership to invest \$20 billion in public and private markets. **B3**
- ◆ **Stablecoin issuer** Bastion received conditional approval for a national trust bank charter. **B3**
- ◆ **Ireland's data-protection** watchdog fined Alphabet's Google the equivalent of \$462.9 million, saying it broke EU rules in its handling of users' location information. **B4**

Worldwide

- ◆ **The U.S. imposed** strict limits on the movement of the Iranian delegation while it is in New York this week to attend meetings of the U.N. General Assembly, emphasizing the peculiarity of warring nations preparing to hear one another in a forum of the kind. **A1**
- ◆ **The Trump administration** proposed investing \$5 billion in a new fund that would help Middle East countries rebuild energy infrastructure battered in the Iran war. **A6**
- ◆ **An equipment outage** snarled air travel across the U.S. Northeast, significantly delaying passengers and diverting flights. **A3**
- ◆ **OpenAI asked** the U.S. government to lead an effort with other countries to develop global safety and security standards for building artificial-intelligence systems. **A3**
- ◆ **Major television** networks agreed to suspend a rotation of broadcast journalists who cover Trump after the White House removed CNN from a planned assignment. **A4**
- ◆ **Romanian gangs** are defrauding the U.S. public purse of hundreds of millions of dollars in program benefits, aided by states' antiquated magnetic-stripe technology. **A1**
- ◆ **German Chancellor** Friedrich Merz pledged to proceed with an unpopular economic overhaul despite personal setbacks and blows to his party and coalition. **A8**
- ◆ **Tropical Storm Polo** will rapidly intensify in the Pacific Ocean and become a major hurricane later this week, forecasters said. **A8**

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Opponents of the Iranian government gather to protest on Monday in New York near the United Nations.

As War Rages, Iran's Delegation Comes to U.S.—Under Tight Rein

Country's president is set to speak later this week, a move with little precedent

By JAMES T. AREDDY AND BENOIT FAUCON

When a small Iranian delegation, led by the country's president, travels to New York this week, its members will be free to attend the United Nations General Assembly—but not to go for a walk in Central Park or shop on Fifth Avenue without permission. Only a trip down the block from their Manhattan hotel to the U.N.

building is allowed.

The U.S. has long imposed restrictions on Tehran's diplomats, but the circumstances of the Iranian delegation are particularly unusual this year as they visit an America their country is fighting in a nearly seven-month-old war.

There is little precedent for the U.S. to host national leaders from a country at war with Washington, even during the U.N. General Assembly when thousands of foreign officials converge on New York.

Even more unusual, President Masoud Pezeshkian of Iran is expected to speak at the U.N. on Wednesday, giving him a platform to rail against

the U.S. and try to sway the world to Iran's side.

"As a matter of optics, it's bizarre," said Marko Milanovic, a professor of international law at the University of Reading in the U.K. But he pointed out that the U.S., as the U.N.'s host nation, is obligated to permit foreign dignitaries to attend the assembly. "Legally this is not remarkable."

During this week's visit, Pezeshkian and his associates will be subject to limitations while on U.S. soil. The stepped-up controls from the Trump administration introduced last year prohibit the delegates from buying luxury goods or shopping at certain stores in-

cluding Costco and Sam's Club without State Department permission. The State Department cited regulations including measures "to protect the interests of the United States."

Since 2024, the State Department has allowed the delegation to travel only from the airport to their hotel—a Millennium Hilton, where they have stayed repeatedly since 2013—and to and from the U.N. headquarters down the block.

Under a 1947 agreement es-

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- ◆ **Saudis return to risky Hormuz route..... A6**
- ◆ **Twin sisters face wrath of Iran's crackdown..... A6**

Foreign Criminal Rings Scam Welfare Recipients

By SCOTT CALVERT AND DAN FROSCH

On a chilly day in March, a twice-deported Romanian national walked into a 7-Eleven in Toledo, Ohio, and secretly affixed a device called a skimmer to a credit card machine, prosecutors said. The man was allegedly part of a California-based criminal crew led by a fellow Romanian nicknamed Piranha.

The gang's aim, according to criminal charges, was to steal food-stamp benefits from customers who swiped their government-issued debit cards at the convenience store.

Court records show informants helped foil the plot. But authorities said the operation mirrors a playbook Romanian crime groups are using across the U.S. to swindle hundreds of millions of dollars in public benefits. Reliance by states on antiquated magnetic-stripe technology makes it easier.

The gangs depend on secretive "builders" who construct skimming devices that are easy to miss, investigators said. The proceeds pay for rented luxury cars and homes with infinity pools, according to authorities. Cash in the form of crypto is spirited back to Romania and flows to real estate, gambling and crime bosses.

Since 2020, dozens of Romanian nationals have been prosecuted for welfare-card skimming in cities including McComb, Miss.; Laurel, Md.; and Portland, Ore. More than 50 people, many with Roma-

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PERSONAL JOURNAL

The three dreaded words no one wants to hear: What's for dinner? **A10**



JASON GAY

Oregon's 84-0 win triggers debate about the value of record-padding games. **A16**

Pilates Is Making Gym Bros Shake Like a Chihuahua

Men enter with swagger and leave broken; 'Ma'am, I can't even lift my legs.'

By JAMIE WATERS

Kedric Walker Jr. thought he was in for a "cute little workout."

He was joining his wife, Sabrina Walker, for a class at Solidcore, a trendy chain where fitness buffs sweat it out on Pilates-inspired reformer machines.

Then the doors closed and "the instructor started yelling at me like we were at an auction," said Kedric, a full-time firefighter and a CrossFit regular in Birmingham, Ala. All around him, women half his size were "rocking it." An hour later, he emerged tired and hungry, his legs shaking like a Chihuahua's.

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Miami Has Plans For Cuba's Future

Cuban-Americans draft detailed blueprints, fueled by Trump's promises

By JOSÉ DE CÓRDOBA AND VERA BERGENGRUEN

MIAMI—At a sprawling waterfront mansion facing Biscayne Bay, a group of wealthy Cuban-Americans has spent months hatching detailed plans for a country that doesn't yet exist.

"We have waited for 67 years," Juan Omar Sixto, 82, a former tobacco farmer who heads the newly formed Cuban-American National Chamber of Commerce, told

the group on a balmy evening in June as they met close to a pool ringed by faux-marble statues of semineude Roman nymphs. "We need to start."

The group has been drawing up blueprints for a Cuban stock exchange and an investment summit in Havana. Elsewhere in Miami, prominent Cuban-Americans are mapping out a provisional government, recruiting engineers to study floating power stations, and strategizing on

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IRS Targets Popular Way Of Passing Along Wealth

By ASHLEA EBELING

Wealthy Americans have for years used a popular type of trust to transfer fortunes to their children without paying hefty gift and estate taxes. Now they are on high alert.

The Internal Revenue Service is calling foul on an heir-ess who used the strategy—and is slapping her and her husband with a \$736 million tax bill. Chuck and Trisha Elcan of Nashville, Tenn., are fighting back in U.S. Tax Court, disputing the agency's claim that they made missteps with grantor-retained annuity trusts, or GRATs, which they used to shift money to their three daughters.

The Elcan case offers a look inside the complex strategies the ultrarich deploy to build intergenerational wealth and

how those tactics can sometimes test the boundaries of tax rules.

The couple said the tactics that the IRS is calling out are valid. The moves—which are used routinely by others—were tied to GRATs that included shares of HCA Healthcare, a major operator of hospitals that Trisha's father and grandfather helped co-found in 1968.

"The position the IRS is taking produces a draconian result," said John Porter, the couple's lawyer, who contends that the operation of the Elcan GRATs was legitimate.

At the heart of the case is a strategy that has become especially popular with corporate executives and investors with sizable stockholdings as markets have roared in recent

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